

2.4 Cascading Style Sheets (CSS)

Once your Web site grows beyond a few pages, you will want to maintain a consistent look and feel across all pages with consistent formatting, design and layout. The trouble starts when you have to change one single element in your format and want it replicated across all your Web pages. Updating each page manually can get tedious if you have 20-odd pages, and a Herculean task if you have 100 pages or more.

Cascading Style Sheets or CSS enable you to separate the content of your HTML documents from the presentation. A single file or a small group of files could define the presentation format for your entire Web site. Thus, any format or presentation changes required across the Web site would be controlled through these CSS files.

For style sheets to work, it is important that your HTML is error-free. You can use the HTML Tidy tool (<http://tidy.sourceforge.net>) to automatically fix errors as well as tidy up the markup for easier reading and editing.

2.4.1 The Basics

To define styles, you use the `<style>` element. To define properties for the documents, you specify the attributes for the document tags within the `<style>`. When defining the style for a template HTML file, the style element is placed within the document `<head>` and not the `<body>`.

```
<html>
<head>
<title> Document Title </title>
<style type="text/css">
  body { color: black; background: white; }
</style>
</head>
<body>
```